

ALLIED FIGHT From right, CM Satheesan with IUML's Panakkad Shahid Thangal and P.K. Kunhalikutty

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KERALA

ARC OF A RAINBOW MINISTRY

Satheesan finds himself in an embattled zone at the outset, but he doubles down on 'Team UDF' with five IUML ministers

By **Jeemon Jacob**

IF YOU FEEL VADASSERY DAMODARAMENON SATHEESAN is a mouthful, that's exactly what four restaurants in Dubai offered to anyone carrying the operative part of that name. Yes, free meals were on offer for any expat Malayali who could prove he was called 'Satheesan'. The ascension of Kerala's new chief minister also saw celebrations in more hardscrabble quarters. ASHA volunteers, who had staged an epic 265-day sit-in outside the state secretariat against the Pinarayi Vijayan government in 2025, found their demand for higher wages granted on the first day. So did anganwadi workers. But as the new Congress CM set off the blocks with a welfarist spree, he may soon realise there is no such thing in politics as a free lunch.

The fiscal complexities he has to grapple with are for later. To begin with, he has perceptions to conquer. Satheesan may be one of a vanishingly rare species in contemporary Indian politics: one willing to inhabit an unapologetically secular space, in deed as much as in word. Yet, he finds himself in an embattled zone right